The pain of double rent was soothed a bit by the fact that on the same day I got the balance of the advance of "Grow Old Along with Me"—$315 after Pohl had taken his share.

Walter Bradbury, by the way, wrote to ask me for a different title for the book, since Grow Old Along with Me did not sound like science fiction, and, indeed, carried romantic implications. He was quite right. On the twenty-fifth, I decided to change the title to Pebble in the Sky.

We got a welcome break over the Fourth of July weekend, when the Boyds, who had not yet left for Egypt, took us out to their summer place in New Hampshire. It was in beautiful countryside, 3^2 hours northwest of Boston, and far away from everything. There was a sense of complete isolation (no neighbors in sight, no telephone) that made all trouble seem to disappear. The Boyds said that they considered it their true home.

They called it "Kasr ed-Dam," which was Arabic for "House of Blood." There was nothing ghoulish about that. It was just that blood groups were Bill's specialty and that both he and Lyle had traveled much in the Middle East and had studied the blood groups of mummies, for instance.

The one difficulty as far as we were concerned was that the house

was so isolated that it had neither electricity nor plumbing. In the twilight, kerosene lamps were lit. The light was unsatisfactory, though we could play bridge by it. On the other hand, we couldn't really drain the kerosene reserves by keeping them burning very long, which meant going to bed unusually early even though it was near the summer solstice and the day stayed fairly bright till past 8:00 p.m.

The absence of plumbing was worse. There was an outhouse, which could be reached by going through the woodshed. I objected seriously to the smell and to the flies, but over a four-day period there was no way in which I could avoid resorting to it a number of times.

The first morning I wandered vaguely about looking for a shower, and it slowly dawned on me that there wasn't one. I put the problem to the Boyds, who seemed a little surprised that it should concern me. I had to settle for sponging myself with lukewarm water in the woodshed, which was better than nothing but which left me unsatisfied.

Even considering the lack of these creature comforts, we had a wonderful time, however, and we loved Bill and Lyle. It made it all the worse to go back